

PHIL 110-15 – INTRODUCTION TO CRITICAL THINKING

Department of Philosophy
San Francisco State University

Fall 2019

Time 8:00-9:15am, Tuesday & Thursday
Humanities 286

Instructor: Matthew Madruga
E-mail: mmadruga@mail.sfsu.edu
Office Hours: Tuesday 2:00-4:00pm
Office: HUM 391A
Phone: (415) 338-1022

ABOUT THE COURSE

This course is designed to improve the critical thinking skills associated with various forms of reasoning. The process of reasoning involves identifying, analyzing, evaluating, and constructing arguments. We will begin by learning to recognize and analyze simple and complex arguments, to distinguish matters of fact from issues of judgment or opinion, and to identify deductive and inductive logical processes. Then, will learn formal methods for evaluating deductive and inductive arguments and develop an understanding of informal fallacies of language and thought. Finally, we will learn to use these reasoning skills to analyze, criticize, and advocate ideas, and to construct our own well-written and well-supported arguments. Throughout the course, we will emphasize the principles of critical thinking as they apply to different forms of reasoning and various current issues. The critical thinking skills learned in this course will enhance students' reasoning in a wide variety of academic disciplines and prepare students to participate in constructive discourse with people with diverse perspectives. This course satisfies the following General Education requirement: A3: Critical Thinking.

STUDENT LEARNING OUTCOMES

1. Understand and articulate basic principles of formal reasoning and their relation to language, and be able to communicate in language that meets the standards of logic
2. Analyze, criticize and advocate ideas
3. Identify common formal and informal fallacies of reasoning, both to avoid these in their own thinking and to criticize these in thinking presented to them
4. Construct elementary valid deductive arguments, including being able to identify and assess overtly expressed premises, suppressed premises, and conclusion
5. Construct elementary sound inductive arguments, including being able to identify and assess hypotheses and evidence
6. Distinguish matters of fact from issues of judgment or opinion, and construct arguments that reach valid or well-supported factual and judgmental conclusions

7. Demonstrate ethical conduct in reasoning, meeting at least the following standards for respectful participation in the community of learners: accurately stating and not misrepresenting the strength of logical connections, not misleading others regarding the truth status of empirical claims, providing full citation or attribution of other people's views, adhering to the "principle of generosity" in reporting or interpreting other people's views.

TEXTS

All textbooks for this class are open access, available free of charge. You can read them online or download them at the links below.

Brad Dowden, *Logical Reasoning* (2018), <https://www.csus.edu/indiv/d/dowdenb/4/Logical-Reasoning.pdf>

Paul Walker, *One Hundred Years of Chemical Warfare: Research, Deployment, Consequences* (Springer, 2017), https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-3-319-51664-6_20

Janni Aragon and Mariel Miller, *Global Women's Issues: Women in the World Today* (BCcampus, 2012), <https://open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/global-women-s-issues-women-in-the-world-today-extended-version>

Julian Baggini https://innasavynska.files.wordpress.com/2018/11/julian-baggini-the-pig-that-wants-to-be-eaten_-and-ninety-nine-other-thought-experiments-granta-books-2010.pdf

Additional readings will be available on iLearn.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS

Exams

There will be two in-class, closed book exams:

- *Exam 1* – This exam will cover material from sections I-III of the course. It will take place on September 24th.
- *Exam 2* – This exam will cover material from sections IV-VI of the course. It will take place on October 31st.

Study guides will be provided for each exam. Although the exams will not be cumulative, they will presuppose a thorough understanding of the previous parts of the course. Be sure to contact your instructor immediately if you are having difficulty with the course material.

Homework Assignments

Homework is an essential part of this course, as it provides an opportunity to practice the skills you are expected to master. Homework will be assigned for nearly every day of class; specific assignment are listed in the course schedule below. Homework is due on the dates list in the Course Schedule. E.g., General Exercises 1-4, p. 67 (of the Downden text) are due on Sept. 5. Late homework will receive a 2 point penalty for each day late. Homework will not be accepted after the assignment has been graded, usually one week after it is due. You may miss five homework assignments without penalty. If you complete all the homework assignments, then the lowest give homework scores will be dropped.

Researching, Analyzing, and Advocating Ideas (RAAI) Assignment

In addition to the regular homework assignments, there will be a short writing assignment in which apply the skills learned in Parts I-VI of the class. Your essay should address one of the topics discussed in Part VII of the course. It should include the following: (a) utilizing a plan for acquiring and recording information employing basic search strategies to explore core sources, including library resources; (b) articulating and applying rudimentary criteria in evaluation information and sources; and (c) using and citing properly the information in assignments. All components of the assignment must meet the basic standards of ethical conduct in reasoning. Complete guidelines will be distributed in class. The RAAI assignment will be completed in two parts:

- A short, one-page RAAI proposal will be due on November 7th. Late proposals will receive a 5 point penalty for each day late.
- Final RAAI assignments will be due on December 19th. Late assignments will receive a 5 point penalty for each day late. RAAI assignments will not be accepted after December 25th.

Class Participation and Attendance

Regular attendance and active participation in discussions and classroom activities are essential parts of this course. You will be expected to attend every class and to be prepared to discuss the assigned readings and your homework. You will be allotted one absence, no questions asked. Each additional absence will lower your attendance and participation grade by 5 points. Late arrival or early departure will count as 1/2 an absence unless excused before the beginning of class.

GRADING SCALE

Exam 1	200 points
Exam 2	200 points
Homework assignments	300 points
RAAI assignment	200 points
Participation and attendance	100 points

The course grade will be based on 1000 total points, as follows: A: 930-1000; A-: 900-929; B+: 870-899; B: 830-869; B-: 800-829; C+: 770-799; C: 730-769; C-: 700-729; D+: 670-699; D: 630-669; D-: 600-629; F: 0-599.

SLO/ASSIGNMENT LINKAGES

SLO	Assignment
1	Parts I-VI homework assignments; exams 1 & 2; RAAI assignment
2	Part VII homework assignments; RAAI assignment
3	Parts III-IV & VII homework assignments; exams 1 & 2; RAAI assignment
4	Parts I & III homework assignments; exam 1; RAAI Assignment

5	Parts I & IV homework assignments; exam 2; RAAI Assignment
6	Parts I-VI homework assignments; exams 1 & 2; RAAI assignment
7	Part II homework assignments; exam 1; RAAI assignment

ADDITIONAL COURSE POLICIES

Classroom Etiquette

It is crucial that class discussions are conducted in a respectful manner, even if heated. Toward this end, you will be expected to be considerate of other class members and their beliefs, ideas, and modes of self-expression. It is sometimes tempting to talk to those around you during a class discussion. This can be disruptive and distracting. I encourage you to refrain from private discussions in the classroom and to be patient with your thoughts until they can be addressed to the class as a whole. Please refrain from all forms of electronic communication during class, including emailing and texting.

Accessibility

Students with disabilities who need reasonable accommodations are encouraged to contact the instructor. The Disability Programs and Resource Center (DPRC) is available to facilitate the reasonable accommodations process. The DPRC is located in the Student Service Building and can be reached by telephone (voice/TTY 415-338-2472) or by email dprc@sfsu.edu.

Religious Holidays

Students who must be absent from class in order to observe religious a holiday must inform the instructor, in writing, about such holidays during the first two weeks of the class each semester. If such holidays occur during the first two weeks of the semester, the student must notify the instructor, in writing, at least three days before the date that he/she will be absent. Students who meet these conditions will not be penalized for their absence, and will be able to make up the work missed.

Plagiarism

Plagiarism is a form of cheating or fraud; it occurs when a student misrepresents the work of another as his or her own. Plagiarism may consist of using the ideas, sentences, paragraphs, or the whole text of another without appropriate acknowledgment, but it also includes employing or allowing another person to write or substantially alter work that a student then submits as his or her own. All assignments will be submitted to the University's plagiarism detection software. Any assignment found to be plagiarized will be given an "F" grade. A second instance of plagiarism will result in an "F" for the course. All instances of plagiarism in the College of Humanities will be reported to the Dean of the College, and may be reported to the University Judicial Affairs Officer for further action.

Campus Safety

SF State fosters a campus free of sexual violence including sexual harassment, domestic violence, dating violence, stalking, and/or any form of sex or gender discrimination. If you disclose a personal experience as an SF State student, the course instructor is required to notify the Dean of Students. To disclose any such violence confidentially, contact:

- The SAFE Place - (415) 338-2208; http://www.sfsu.edu/~safe_plc/
- Counseling and Psychological Services Center - (415) 338-2208; <http://psyservs.sfsu.edu/>

For more information on your rights and available resources: <http://titleix.sfsu.edu>

The Learning Assistance Center

The Learning Assistance Center (LAC) provides free, on-campus writing tutoring for SF State students. It offers both one-time and ongoing tutoring sessions, with some same day appointments available. The LAC is open Monday through Friday from 9am-4pm and Friday from 9am-12pm. For more information and to schedule an appointment, see <http://www.sfsu.edu/~lac/index.html>.

COURSE SCHEDULE (subject to change)

I. Introduction to Reasoning and Arguments

T Aug. 29 Course syllabus

How to reason logically

Th Aug. 31 Read Dowden, Ch. 1

What is an argument?

T Sept. 3 Read Dowden, pp. 23-38
Homework: General Exercises 1-4, p. 67

Types and features of arguments

Th Sept. 5 Dowden, pp. 39-53
Homework: Conditionals 1-4, pp. 76-77; Creating & Improving Arguments 1-2, p. 81-82

II. Reasoning Ethically and Judging Credibility

Principles and strategies

T Sept. 10 Read Dowden, pp. 140-56
Homework: Exercises 1-5, pp. 170-71

Judging credibility in practice

Th Sept. 12 Read Dowden, pp. 156-69
Homework: Exercises 6, 7, 12, 14, 18, 20, pp. 171-76

III. Deductive Reasoning

What is deductive reasoning?

T Sept. 17 Read Dowden, pp. 328-40
Homework: Following-from & Implication, 1-6, pp. 342-43

Logical form and sentential logic

Th Sept. 19 Read Dowden, pp. 350-73

Then, Homework: Logical Equivalence, 1-4, p. 389; The Logic of And, Or, Not, and If
2, 11-12, p. 390, 392
T Sept. 24 **Exam 1**

IV. Inductive Reasoning

What is inductive reasoning?

Th Sept. 26 Read Dowden, pp. 428-44
Homework: Generalizing from a Sample, 1-3, p. 468

Evaluating inductive arguments

T Oct. 1 Read Dowden, pp. 445-62
Homework: Generalizing from a Sample, 10 (all parts), p. 472

V. Precision in Argumentation

Ambiguity and vagueness

Th Oct. 3 Read Dowden, pp. 89-101
Homework: Imprecision, 1 and 3, p. 124

Precision, operationalization, and definitions

T Oct. 8 Read Dowden, pp. 102-20
Homework: Definitions, 1-4, p. 135

VI. Deception, Fallacies, and Consistency

Defending against deception

Th Oct. 10 Read Dowden, pp. 239-58
Homework: Exercise 1, pg. 260

Detecting fallacies

T Oct. 15 Read Dowden, pp. 264-73
Homework: Exercises 1-5, pp. 286-287

Th Oct. 17 Read Dowden, pp. 274-84
Homework: Exercises 10-17, pp. 288-290

T Oct. 22 Hong Kong Logic website-read section on fallacies

Th Oct. 24 Read "The Pig that Wants to be Eaten" various thought experiments

Consistency and inconsistency

T Oct. 29 Read Dowden, pp. 294-313
Homework: Inconsistency, 1-3, p. 315

Th Oct. 31 **Exam 2**

VII. Logical Reasoning in Practice

Chemical Weapons

- T Nov. 5 Read Walker, "A Century of Chemical Warfare: Building a World Free of Chemical Weapons," https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-3-319-51664-6_20 (Note download the book and read pp. 379-400)
Homework: Construct *three* questions to bring to class. You can ask to clarify a concept or a part of the chapter, or you can raise concerns or criticisms about Walker's argument.
- Th Nov. 7 Logic games in class-Instructor will provide 10 problems in logic

Global Justice

- T Nov. 12 Read Chapter 1: "Women and Poverty," in *Global Women's Issues*, <https://open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/global-women-s-issues-women-in-the-world-today-extended-version>
Homework: Discussion questions 1-2, 5, and 7
- Th Nov. 14 Read Sandberg, "Mega-interest on Microcredit: Are Lenders Exploiting the Poor?" iLearn
Homework: Sandberg argues that the four most common arguments against the practice of microlending are unsound. Choose one of Sandberg's arguments and reconstruct it.

Life and Death Issues

- T Nov. 19 Read Thomson, "A Defense of Abortion," iLearn
Homework: Thomson uses several famous examples in her essay: the kidnapped violinist (section 1), tenants in a small house (2) Henry Fonda (3), people-seeds (4), and Henry Fonda redux (5). Choose one these examples. Explain the example and the corresponding argument in your own words. Does Thomson's example accomplish the goal that she intends? Why or why not, exactly?
- Th Nov. 21 Marquis, "Why Abortion is Immoral," iLearn
Homework: Marquis's article has six sections. Identify the thesis or purpose of each section. (You will need to read and digest the material in order to complete this assignment, as some theses are implicit.)

RAAI Proposals Due

- T Nov. 26 No Class-Fall Break
- Th Nov 28 No Class-Thanksgiving Break

Animals

- T Dec 3 Dobson, *Animal Ethics 101*, Chs. 1-2, <http://animaethics101.blogspot.com/>
Homework: Discussion questions 1, 4-5, pp. 24-2
- Th Dec 5 Dobson, *Animal Ethics 101*, Ch. 3, <http://animaethics101.blogspot.com/>
Homework: Discussion questions 1-4, p. 34

T Dec 10 Dobson, *Animal Ethics 101*, Ch. 4, <http://animalethics101.blogspot.com/>
Homework: Discussion questions 1-4, p. 42-43

Th Dec 12 **RAAI Workshop**

RAAI Assignments are due on Dec 19th